Chapter 2

Getting Ready for Life:
Breaking New Ground

KIRAN JOINED THE GOVERNMENT COLLEGE FOR WOMEN AT AMRITSAR after her matriculation. The political science course and the NCC (National Cadet Corps) were the two features that influenced her the most. The other subjects that interested her were philosophy and history. But it was political science that she actually wanted to master. Theories of state administration and powers and functions of governance fired her imagination. She believed this was the subject that helped her to become a participatory citizen and also instilled feelings of nationalism within her.

The NCC gave her the first taste of 'khaki'. She adored and respected her uniform and took great pains to keep it immaculately clean, starched and ironed. With such pride and determination in the corps, it was not surprising that she soon became the platoon commander and was subsequently chosen to lead the annual day parades. She did not know then where her destiny would lead her, but this much was clear that she was proud to be the citizen of a country she loved and wanted to serve it as an active participant and a loyal soldier.

Even during her college days there was always a sense of urgency about her. She was almost always on the run: From the classroom, to the tennis court, to the library, with never a moment wasted. Only very rarely would she give herself the luxury of spending a few minutes with friends over a samosa and a soft drink. All the girls knew that Kiran was not interested in gossip or inane chit-chat and never bothered her with such trivialities either.

Her mother recollects how Kiran possessed this tremendous urge to utilize time to derive the maximum benefit. If she had even a half-hour of unaccounted time on her hands, she would either get down to painting or grab a racket and rush off to the tennis court to play and, if she couldn't find anyone, she would bang away against the wall by herself.

After her theory periods in college she rode back home on her bicycle, spent a few minutes with her mother, slipped into her NCC uniform and rode back to college. Kiran has always been tremendously fond of her mother and in those days she was willing to do the extra mileage on her cycle, about 12 kilometres, just to see her for some time during midday. She could easily have taken her NCC kit to college and changed there itself, but then that would have deprived her of these precious moments. The sisters had but one cycle among them and so it meant carrying her sister Reeta also on the pillion. College life was marked by a hectic period of hard work, discipline and regular studies. She was determined that one day she would do what was not expected from Indian women. What that was going to be was not very clear, but that did not deter her from preparing herself.

The environment in which Kiran was brought up gave her insights into the then generally accepted stereotypes of gender, which came naturally to her and were in no way orchestrated or engineered. The stereotypes were as follows: men for the outdoors, authority and sports and women for the